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The New York Times



Secure Muganzi in his coffee plantation in Uganda trying to access Chinese-based A.I. He uses artificial intelligence-powered tools to help monitor crop conditions, improve farm management and make more informed decisions during growing season.

STUART TIBAWESWA FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

China’s A.I., Cheaper and Easier to Use, Is Winning Over Africa

This article is by **Paul Mozur, Adam Satariano and Aaron Krolik.**

NAIROBI, Kenya — When Ernest Mwebaze, a tech developer in Uganda, was building an artificial intelligence system last year tailored for his country’s many languages, he tested American and Chinese tools to see which one could help.

China’s won.

The A.I. model from the Chinese internet giant Alibaba handled Uganda’s dozens of languages better than anything from Meta or Google, Mr. Mwebaze said. It was also inexpensive, and he could customize the model with his own data.

“We want to build things as cheap as possible, yet have them work really well,” said Mr. Mwebaze, a former research scientist at Google. His system, called Sun-

Providing Challenge to the U.S.’s Dominance

flower, is now used across Uganda, including by farmers to receive weather information and crop advice in local dialects.

Mr. Mwebaze, 47, is one of thousands of developers across Africa

who have turned to Chinese A.I. models in the past year. In Kenya, entrepreneurs are using the models to streamline legal and business services. In Nigeria, they have made educational tools that teach high school students. In Ghana, developers are building local chatbots.

China’s A.I. is surging, especially in developing countries, as

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Activists Allege Israeli Captors Abused Them

This article is by **Catherine Porter, Elisabetta Povoledo and Nimet Kirac.**

PARIS — When Arno Meyns tried to sail to Gaza in May, Israeli forces intercepted his boat at gunpoint, took him to an Israeli ship and, he said, shoved him into a darkened shipping container.

Barefoot and soaked in seawater, Mr. Meyns found up to four men waiting there to attack him, he said.

“They started kicking me right away. It was dark. They punched me, too. They stopped for a moment, and then started again,” said Mr. Meyns, 34, a Belgian who is a captain for small commercial vessels.

Mr. Meyns was among more than 400 activists on a flotilla of roughly 50 boats who were apprehended on the Mediterranean Sea by Israel as they tried to break the Israeli blockade of Gaza.

The stated goal of the activists, who sailed from Turkey on May 14, was to bring food and humanitarian aid to the war-ravaged enclave. In reality, many expected to be detained, like those who had participated in similar flotillas, before reaching the territory. They hoped that media coverage of their journey would call attention to Israel’s restrictions on supplies to Gaza, which tightened after the war began — and which later contributed, experts said, to famine in parts of Gaza.

The activists were captured days after setting sail. Interviews with activists and statements from Israeli officials both show that they were then held by Israel for roughly three days, first at sea aboard Israeli vessels, and later in the Port of Ashdod.

There, Israel’s national security

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JORDAN GALE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Cyclists in Portland, Ore., prepared for the World Naked Bike Ride, a protest tradition that the city has hosted since 2004. This summer, Portland has two competing versions of the nude bike ride.

When Pedaling Naked, It’s a Protest and a Party

By **ANNA GRIFFIN and MAUREEN O’HAGAN**

PORTLAND, Ore. — When political times get tough for liberals, a certain segment of Portland, Ore., reaches for protest in perhaps its barest form: They take off their clothes, climb onto bicycles and ride through the city.

They’ve been doing this since 2004. But this summer, they’re doing it twice.

The city now hosts two competing versions of the World Naked Bike Ride, a global movement that began in Vancouver, British Columbia, in the early 2000s to call attention to oil dependence, bicycle safety and body positivity.

The split has become a surprisingly revealing proxy for a debate

Oregon’s Dueling Rides Are Turning Heads Unapologetically

playing out across the American left: When does a protest stop being a protest? Is building community itself a form of resistance? If everyone is having too much fun, have you lost the plot?

“Is riding a bike and participating in a group bike ride about normalizing bicycling, or is it about changing the world?” said Adonia Lugo, a Los Angeles-based anthropologist who has studied and participated in bicycle protest culture.

What started as a fun — if not earnest — protest, gradually became one of the marquee events in a summer cycling calendar so crowded that, on some weekends, riders can choose from a dozen themed rides celebrating hobbies, pop culture, politics or simply the pleasure of pedaling through the city on a warm evening.

By the early 2020s, as many as 10,000 riders were turning out. Police temporarily closed streets. Organizers sold merchandise. Tourists came to watch.

When organizers paused the event in 2024 to rethink how to safely manage its growing popularity, another group decided Portland didn’t simply need a naked bike ride; it needed one that

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Many in Iran Feel Betrayed By U.S. Vow

Trump Backed Protests, but Aid Never Came

This article is by **Erica L. Green, Zolan Kanno-Youngs, Sanam Mahoozi and Yeganeh Torbati.**

WASHINGTON — In the weeks leading up to the U.S. war with Iran, President Trump cheered on the Iranian protesters rising up against their government, telling them that they should “save the names of the killers and abusers” and that he would come to their aid.

“HELP IS ON ITS WAY,” he promised.

But more than five months into the conflict, liberating the Iranian people has been one of the war’s most glaring unfulfilled objectives.

Iran has executed at least 26 people in connection with the January protests since Mr. Trump made his promise, with many more protesters potentially at risk, according to Amnesty International. U.S. officials believe Iran’s new supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, is even more interested in pursuing a nuclear weapon than his father, who was killed in an airstrike on the opening day of the war.

And as Iranians remain locked in crisis, Mr. Trump is looking for a way out. Negotiators are working on a deal to restart shipping traffic in the Strait of Hormuz, which Iran has effectively shut down, as Mr. Trump tries to extricate the United States from a conflict that has lasted far longer, and proved far more costly, than he anticipated.

In an interview this summer, Mr. Trump acknowledged that he never really believed that the uprising he encouraged would happen anyway because Iranian security forces would crush the demonstrators.

“I never thought, unless they could be completely armed, I never thought they’d have that kind of uprising, because these people are violent,” Mr. Trump told the conservative podcaster Hugh Hewitt.

But for Iranians who listened to Mr. Trump’s early promises, the sense of betrayal is real.

“I genuinely thought that help was on the way, but I was so wrong,” said Vahid, a 35-year-old from Tehran who works at a start-up company, echoing a sentiment expressed by numerous Iranians in interviews with The New York Times. All spoke on the condition that The Times identify them only

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THE WEATHER

Today, humid, partly cloudy, afternoon thunderstorm, high 88. Tonight, cloudy, an evening thunderstorm, low 74. Tomorrow, hot, sunny, high 90. Weather map, Page A24.

CASSIDY TO BACK BLANCHE, SAVING HIS CONFIRMATION

MISGIVINGS SET ASIDE

Two Republicans Remain Opposed to Pick for Attorney General

By **MICHAEL GOLD and CARL HULSE**

WASHINGTON — Senator Bill Cassidy, Republican of Louisiana, said on Friday that he would support Todd Blanche’s nomination as attorney general, effectively saving the confirmation of President Trump’s pick after two other Republican senators said they would oppose him.

Mr. Cassidy, who lost his reelection bid to a Trump-backed challenger, said in a speech on the Senate floor that he had deep concerns about “apparent lawfare,”



ALEX KENT/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Senator Bill Cassidy’s vote will put Todd Blanche over the top.

the phrase he has used to refer to the Justice Department’s targeting of the president’s political enemies.

But Mr. Cassidy said that after much consideration, he had come to believe that Mr. Blanche, who has served as the president’s personal lawyer, would be better positioned to push back against Mr. Trump’s norm-busting demands than an alternative.

“Mr. Blanche is not perfect, and he will tell you this,” Mr. Cassidy said. “But the choice is not between perfection and Mr. Blanche. It is between Mr. Blanche and another acting attorney general, who may not run the department effectively under President Trump.”

He announced his decision hours after Senator Lisa Murkowski of Alaska became the second Republican to oppose Mr. Blanche’s confirmation, joining

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He Trained to Stop a Shooting. In Idaho, He’s a Reluctant Hero.

By **NICHOLAS BOGEL-BURROUGHS**

TWIN FALLS, Idaho — Jordan Salinas did not notice the new sign on the counter at his favorite coffee shop until a barista pointed it out.

Help show your support, the sign read, by contributing to a gift card for Mr. Salinas’s “bravery and selfless act during the recent tragic event.”

Customers had already pooled \$630, the barista noted.

Mr. Salinas, 35, with long hair tucked under a cap and a pistol holstered on his hip, appeared to be taken aback. It didn’t feel right. The donations, the praise, the handshakes. All of it was to thank Mr. Salinas for something he wished had never happened.

He pulled out his wallet and paid for his coffee.

A complex mix of emotions has gripped Twin Falls, Idaho, in the days since a 24-year-old man with a rifle killed three people and wounded seven more at a brand-

new In-N-Out Burger restaurant. This agricultural community — known for its waterways, scenic trails and a failed Evel Knievel stunt in the 1970s — remains in mourning for the dead and injured. Yet there is a shared sentiment that the midday shooting at a crowded strip mall could have been even worse.

The community has held fundraisers for the families of the dead — Christopher Claunch, 59; Ashley Garibay, 23; and Dale Schultz, 66 — as well as for the injured, some of whom have severe injuries. A candlelight vigil drew hundreds and featured an impromptu rendition of “Amazing Grace.” The parking lot of the temporarily closed fast food restaurant is dotted with dozens of flowers.

Amid this outpouring of support, and the Twin Falls Police Department’s pledge to fully investigate, so much about the attack re-

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BUSINESS B1-6

The Dwindling Rhine

Record low water in Europe’s vital economic artery is choking commerce across the continent.

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Hardball at FIFA

Top officials were given an ultimatum when a plan to sell shares in the soccer body was presented to them.

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INTERNATIONAL A4-9

School Massacre in Thailand

A student killed his grandparents before opening fire at his high school, the authorities said. The episode revived a debate about gun laws.

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Worse Than Ugly?

London’s Barbican was once voted England’s ugliest building. Now some say a new neighbor will ruin it.

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OBITUARIES A20-21

Maker of Abruzzo Wines

Emidio Pepe, 94, made a case for local grapes and traditional methods, inspiring a younger generation.

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ARTS C1-6

Dance and Jazz, Reunited

The choreographer Kayla Farrish, above, and the bassist Esperanza Spalding are improvising together.

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Chills Delivered Offscreen

The longtime horror-movie director John Carpenter has found a new way to give people nightmares.

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NATIONAL A10-19

Reporting Southeast Asians

The Trump administration is sending back record numbers of Vietnamese, Laotians and Hmong. Many came to the United States as young war refugees and later committed crimes.

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‘Riled Up’ Over Defiant Teen

An officer’s use of physical force on a high school student, one of thousands of such episodes in Texas in recent years, underscores long-held concerns about policing in schools.

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TRAVEL C7-9

36 Hours in Sifnos

Fresh energy has washed over this Greek island, driven in part by a flourishing food scene led by chefs who are using far-flung techniques.

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